

Inerrancy

TH311-35 Theology 1: Prolegomena and Bibliology

Dennis Gahm

Introductory Paragraph

Inerrancy is the topic of this paper. Limited inerrancy is the view that I espouse. This teaches that the Bible may have errors but that these errors are minor and that all of the doctrines of the Bible are inerrant and infallible. I believe that the Bible was never meant to be a book that has everything and all the details correct. Just as Second Timothy says, the book of the Bible is good for training in righteousness. It does not say that the Bible is good for all of the scientific facts.

I believe the Bible does have many errors. And if I were to ask you to point them out, I would not be surprised if you point out many. However, I believe the Bible is infallible, although it may not be inerrant or absolutely inerrant. What I mean is that 2 Timothy 3:16 says, "All scripture is God-breathed." I agree. And this word God-breathed is often translated as inspired. I believe that the scripture is inspired and infallible, but not inerrant. I believe in limited inerrancy. I believe that the Scripture is profitable for teaching and rebuke and training in righteousness, and not necessarily for science and all details and numbers.

The Bible contains errors. Even supporters of inerrancy say so. Just show them numbers, the minor errors in textual criticism, and the fact that none of Jesus' words are recorded word for word. Jeremiah is accidentally spoken of as Isaiah in the gospel of Matthew. Numbers are wrong in the Old Testament. The inerrancy supporter would say these are minor errors, but inerrancy says that for all matters of importance, the Bible got it right. This includes science, history, and all the small details. However, as Michael Horton says, the Bible does not teach young earth - it simply does not teach anything. What I am saying here is that agnosticism is the right approach to all things. Agnosticism is philosophically sound. What I mean is that we simply do not know.

I think we forgot that Christianity is about faith not sight. So yes, you can place your faith in inerrancy; but I think it is wrong to say that if we have faith not in inerrancy we have wrong faith. What I'm saying is that some of us have the right to place our faith in limited inerrancy and still have good faith. I'm so surprised that people think Princeton Seminary and Fuller Seminary are totally evil and apostate. They simply have a slightly different view on inerrancy. This sounds more like Pharisticalism. What I

meant to say is that faith can be placed in inerrancy, and it is not faith that has to be inerrant or not. Inerrancy is just not a crucial issue if one simply believes in limited inerrancy.

This class is about Bibliology. One question I want to ask the inerrantist is: why do you believe the canon is correct and inspired? They will simply say, "God made it so." But they believe this because of the handed down doctrine that this is the correct canon. It is a human doctrine - even if it is a doctrine from God. To highlight this fact, if I say, "This book of Dennis is inspired and is part of the canon," the doctrinist would say, "No. The canon is closed." Why? Because someone long time ago said so. What I am trying to emphasize is: we are placing faith in man-made doctrines. This is faith. Faith in doctrines. And inerrancy is a doctrine. Yes, the Bible says to teach "sound doctrines," but we should always be agnostic and challenge our presumptions.

The Bible was not meant to get all the details right. When the book of Genesis is created, it is not trying to convey science. It is a book on God's power and love. I would like to say that God knows science perfectly, but the Bible is a man made book in a certain context of history and culture and science. Thus, if those human environments are wrong, then the Bible is not wrong, it is simply a human book. But God inspires and does not dictate and so although some details are wrong, the Bible is right in the terms of being "profitable in rebuke, and training in righteousness." So the Bible is right in doctrines and spiritual matters, but not always right in science and all the details of human context.

This is shown in that prophecies are used in the language given to the people at the time, and not the language of 5000 years later. Imagine, if Genesis is to be

completely factually and scientifically correct for all time, the language it uses must be incredibly technical for even the word light. The movement of the light as a wave should be explained somewhere in the Old Testament. This is simply not the case. The Bible's purpose is to simply show the character of God.

In my opinion, the real reason why there is an in seed the paint is because Dss and scholars are trying to create an issue so that they can have a reason to get paid. I understand that and he has an important issue but it is very clear that it is a dividing issue - and this should not be. The reason is this issue is more of an academic issue where we ponder all of the details and iron out all of the nuances of theology. It should not have Fuller seminary, or Michael Horton to be called apostate. the reason why I am attending Faith seminary is because Fuller seminary and Western Seminary rejected me. I have heard from so many people that Fuller seminary will lead me astray from the Faith. I really believe this is not the case. Inerrancy is not that big of an issue. Also, the position that many liberals take is that of limited inerrancy and infallibility, which is very similar to absolute inerrancy.

Having different beliefs and different theologies should be encouraged. this has always been the case in the Protestant church. Is it not the Catholics who created a single system that corrupted Christianity? Rick Warren says that difference isn't theology simply show that people are different. Just as God created the color green and the color red, everyone should have their own unique theology. The problem with everyone believing in the same theology is that they will not be genuine. It will ultimately be a cult. They will not know why they believe certain doctrines - they will only believe in the doctrines that they are told to believe by the most charismatic

Protestant leader. That is why it is so important to go back to the Bible and to have a good academic education. And when I say academic education I do not mean indoctrination. In fact I mean the opposite: just as I am writing this paper, education should have people think for themselves and come up with their own ideas. Should this not be the same case for theology?

Now I understand that there is something called correct Doctrine and Orthodox teaching, but I honestly find so many of the inherent proponents to be blindsided and cult-minded. Correct Doctrine should never be espoused with authority and with crushing blows. Simply look at Jesus. The Bible says to gently correct, and to gently teach, so that they may have the grace to understand the truth. Now even Paul and Barnabas disagreed sharply. But they were reunited later. So is the case with infallibility. It says that the Bible is still correct in all of its doctrines. Is this not enough?

In conclusion absolute inerrancy and limited in there and see are the two issues that stand before the church. In my opinion, it is the greatest debate in all of Protestant circles right now. However, I find this a very sad truth because the greatest debate should be a debate of how we can save the Lost. Although I believe in limited inerrancy, I believe that the Bible is profitable for teaching, correction, and training in righteousness. Therefore, I hope that all Christians can espouse my beliefs. I believe that the greater issue is how to save the lost people, and it is actually Satan's plan to cause us to divide on the issue of inerrancy. I pray that non-Christians will not see Christians fighting amongst themselves, walk away from the faith, and mock the Christians.